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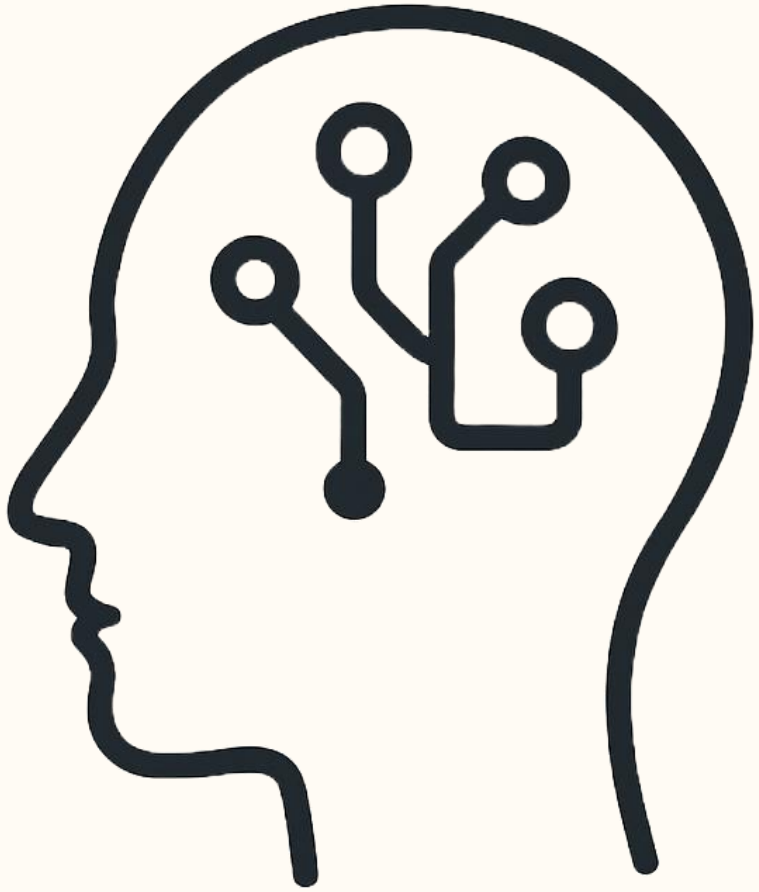
Elevating BetterHelp to the forefront of Digital Mental Health Space with Ethical, Human-Centered AI



Team 03

Team Introduction

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- Introduction
- Pain Points And Solutions
- Technology Deployment Strategy
- Strategic Advantage Over Compitators
- Conclusion

AI In Digital Therapy Is Functioning - But Still Falling Short

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Current AI Implementation at Better Help:

Matches Patients to therapist under **30 seconds**.

AI chatbots used for:

- **Initial Client Screening**
- **Session Summaries**

But Challenges Remain:

AI generated summaries often miss **emotional nuances**.

Therapist report increased **administrative burden**

FTC fined Better Help **$7.8M** for data privacy violations.

Better Help must refine its AI to support therapists, improve outcomes, and build trust while staying ethical, transparent, and compliant.

A Growing Market Amid a Growing Crisis

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Post Covid:

1 in 5

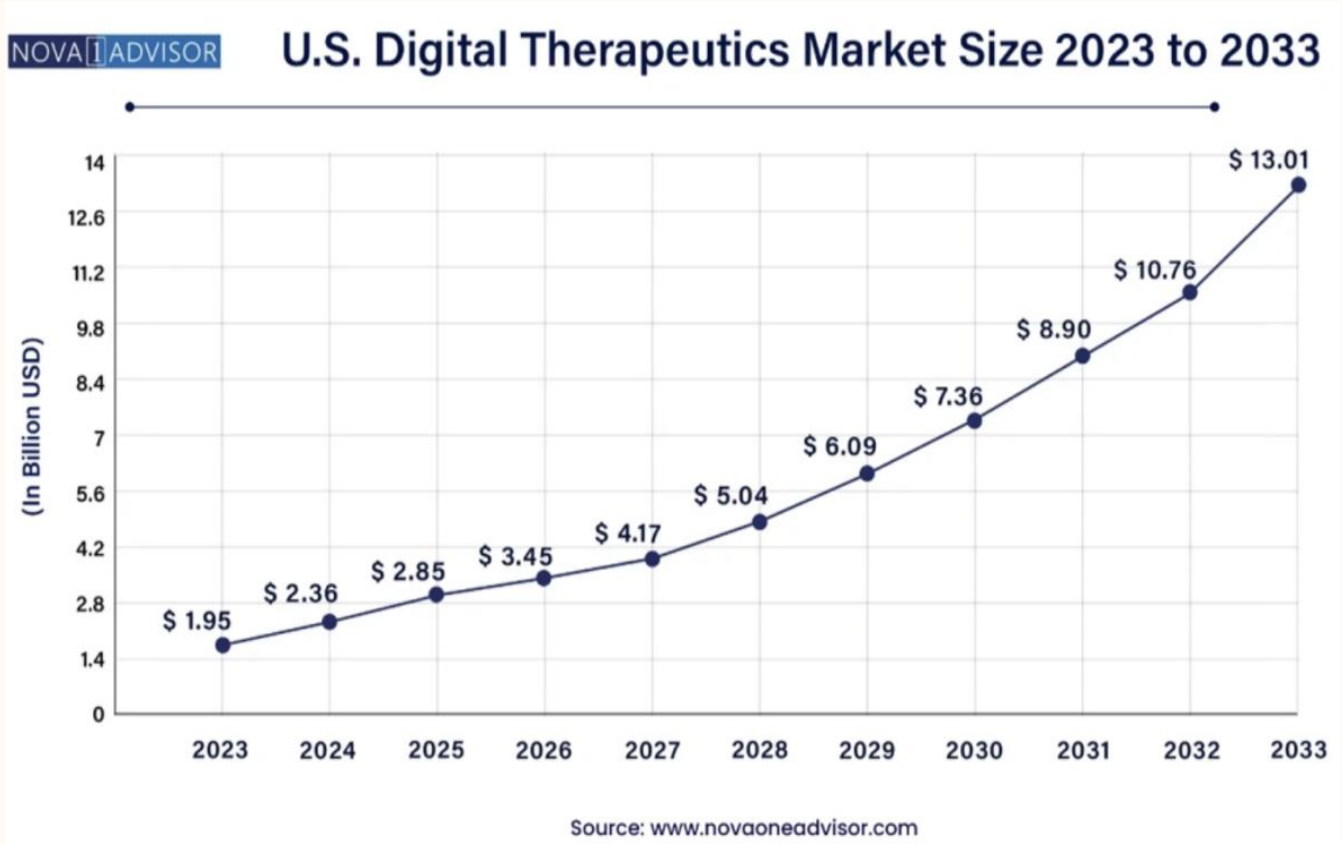
U.S adults needs mental health support

Over 160M

Americans resides in Mental Health Professional Shortage Areas

54.7%

of adults with a mental illness receive no treatment.



CAGR: 20.9%

Introducing the People Behind the Problems

Alex Johnson:

He is a 29-year-old high school teacher from Detroit. He has struggled with obesity since college and have started showing signs of moderate depression. He finds it difficult to seek help for himself and avoids in-person therapy due to stigma and time constraints.

a) Uses BetterHelp for anxiety and depression support.

b) He likes digital tools but struggles to feel “heard” by AI.

c) He is concerned about who sees his therapy data.

Maya Flint:

She is a 43-year-old licensed therapist based in Chicago, specializing in trauma-informed and culturally sensitive care. She has over a decade of experience working with clients from diverse backgrounds, particularly those dealing with complex trauma. She is passionate about creating a safe space for healing and focuses on empowering clients.

a) Open to technology, but feels overwhelmed by the effort needed to correct AI outputs

b) Cautious about using tools that may introduce bias or reduce her control over sessions

Restoring Empathy & Easing Burden with Smarter AI

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Maya's Core Need – Control Over Treatment Decisions
"AI can offer support, but the final decision must always be mine."

Solutions:

- Differentiate AI suggestions from therapist actions (e.g., tags like "AI-generated – therapist approval required")
- Build an override mechanism allowing therapists to review, or reject AI inputs
- System where therapists can turn off AI prompts when not helpful

Alex's Challenge – Emotional Disconnect
"The therapy summaries I get sound robotic… it's like they didn't capture how I was really feeling."

Solutions:

- Integrate emotion-aware AI (e.g., Affectiva) to analyze sentiments in real-time
- Enable therapist-reviewed summaries before delivery to clients
- Include a client feedback prompt after each summary (e.g., "Did this reflect your experience?")

Maya's Challenge – Time-Consuming Corrections, Administrative Overload
"AI-generated notes miss key therapeutic context. I end up rewriting a lot of it by hand."

Solutions:

- Train the AI using Maya's past documentation style to mirror her voice
- Use smart, editable templates that make it quicker to adjust than to rewrite
- Keep the therapist firmly in control by making AI suggestions fully optional and editable

Building Trust and Equity in AI Therapy

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Alex's Concern – Data Privacy & Consent

"I'm not sure who has access to my therapy data. That makes me anxious."

- Apply end-to-end encryption for all session data (text, audio, video)
- Show clear, opt-in consent prompts before using AI features
- Include visible data security certifications and transparency dashboards in the app

Maya's Concern – AI Bias & Fairness

"What if the AI gives inappropriate advice because it wasn't trained on clients like mine?"

- Train AI on diverse, inclusive datasets covering ethnicity, gender, age, and cultural backgrounds
- Audit AI output regularly with fairness metrics and demographic testing
- Create an Ethical AI Review Board to guide system development

Embedding Real-Time AI to Strengthen Therapeutic Precision and Quality

Live Session Input
Multimodal data (video, voice, transcript) streamed via HIPAA-compliant WebRTC

AI Processing Layer
AI interprets facial cues, voice tone, and speech to identify emotional changes

Therapist Dashboard
Provides real-time insights and post-session summaries to highlight missed cues and key moments.

Therapist Experience	Enables therapists to access **real-time, non-intrusive insights** during live video sessions
	Helps therapists maintain **session continuity and focus** without needing to take real-time notes**.**
	Enhances the therapist's ability to **respond empathetically and with greater clinical precision.**
Clinical Effectiveness	**Captures emotional shifts and sentiment cues** for proactive response
	Reduces clinical blind spots, allowing for **early intervention and deeper therapeutic engagement**
	Acts as a **second set of eyes and ears**, ensuring critical cues are not overlooked during live sessions**.**

This deployment enhances therapeutic precision, safeguards client trust while ensuring therapists remain the central decision-maker and positions BetterHelp at the forefront of AI-enabled care

From Insight to Implementation: How AI Reshapes the Therapy Workflow

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Without AI

- Therapist manually interprets emotion
- Notes written manually post-session
- High variance in therapist documentation
- Cues sometimes missed in fast-paced sessions

With AI Support

- Therapist sees live AI-generated emotional cues
- Effective AI-assisted session summaries auto-generated
- Standardized insights improve consistency
- AI flags subtle voice/facial changes in real-time

Therapist Impact

- AI relieves therapists from cognitive overload and documentation
- Enables more time for client interaction and reflection
- Accelerates onboarding for new therapists with built-in AI-guided quality assurance

Platform Efficiency

- Reduces variability in service quality across 35,000+ therapist network
- Standardizes therapy delivery regardless of location or experience
- Supports BetterHelp's ability to scale without compromising session integrity

Strategic Advantage

- Creates defensible IP and operational model competitors lack
- Positions BetterHelp as an AI-augmented mental health pioneer
- Aligns platform with long-term trends: hybrid care, clinician enablement, ethical AI

AI deployment transforms BetterHelp's therapist model from fragmented and manual into a standardized, scalable, and insight driven system that enables better care at scale.

Unique Solutions Which Makes BetterHelp Industry Leader

AI aiding Therapist

AI to Empower Therapists, Not Replaces Them

BetterHelp is deploying **real-time AI tools** that **assist therapists** like therapist Maya during live sessions, **detecting emotional shifts** and **surfacing actionable insights**. This allows therapists to respond more **empathetically** making sessions more **personal and effective.**

Operational Efficiency Without Losing Empathy

AI streamlines **session summaries** and **risk flagging**, reducing admin work so **therapists can focus on care**. This leads to higher session **quality** and **better retention** for clients like Alex, while supporting therapist satisfaction and continuity.

Efficiency + Empathy

Privacy & Trust

Industry-Leading Data Privacy & Trust

After regulatory scrutiny, BetterHelp now leads with **HIPAA/FTC-compliant privacy**, **end-to-end encryption**, anonymized AI training, and transparent opt-in consent-rebuilding user trust.

What Sets Betterhelp Apart

Unlike Woebot or Headspace (**chatbot-only**), every BetterHelp client is matched with a licensed therapist, supported by AI but never replaced.

Unlike Talkspace, BetterHelp is pioneering **real-time, emotion-aware AI** to guide therapists live -something competitors do not offer.

Only BetterHelp **combines AI-enabled, human-led care** at scale with **transparent, ethical innovation**.

While competitors integrate technology in mental health delivery, BetterHelp's approach is uniquely **human-centered**.

The distinction lies not in whether AI is used, but how it's used

BetterHelp's AI: Empowering Human Care, Driving Business Growth

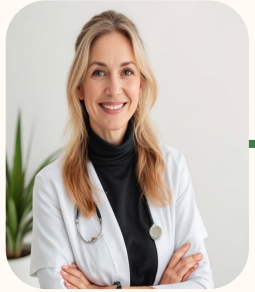
Human Impact

Emotional Connection Restored

- Alex, once feeling disconnected, now experiences more **empathetic sessions** through **real-time emotion-aware AI** that also helps Dr. Maya respond to subtle **emotional shifts**.

Privacy and Security Reassured

- Alex's **privacy concerns** are addressed via **end-to-end encryption**, opt-in consent, and anonymized **AI training**, ensuring full data **protection**.



Reduced Administrative Burden

- Dr. Maya, previously overwhelmed by **manual** tasks, now **benefits** from **AI-generated summaries** and risk alerts, allowing greater **focus** on **client care**.

Therapist Authority Preserved

- AI provides **real-time emotional insights**, while therapists **retain** full decision-making control, **preserving** clinical **autonomy** and therapeutic **integrity**.

Therapist Dashboard Empowerment

- Through the dashboard, Dr. Maya receives live **emotional cues** and post-session **insights**, enabling deeper **engagement without** increasing **workload.**

Therapy feels more **human** and **connected** for Alex, and more **efficient** and **empowering** for Dr. Maya.

AI **strengthens** the connection, **not replaces** it.

Business Impact

Enhanced Session Quality & Scalable Growth

- **Higher** client **retention**, deeper **engagement**, and **improved** therapist **satisfaction** - driving long-term, **sustainable revenue growth**.

Operational Efficiency

- **Scalable** therapist **network** without sacrificing care **standards**.

Ethical Leadership

- **Rebuilding** user **trust** through industry-leading **privacy**, **security**, and **transparency** measures.

Competitive Advantage

- **Positioning** BetterHelp at the **forefront** of **human-centered AI** in mental health, far ahead of bot-driven or static models.

BetterHelp is not just **scaling** therapy — it is **redefining** the future of **ethical**, **empathetic digital mental health care**.

Questions?

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Thank you!

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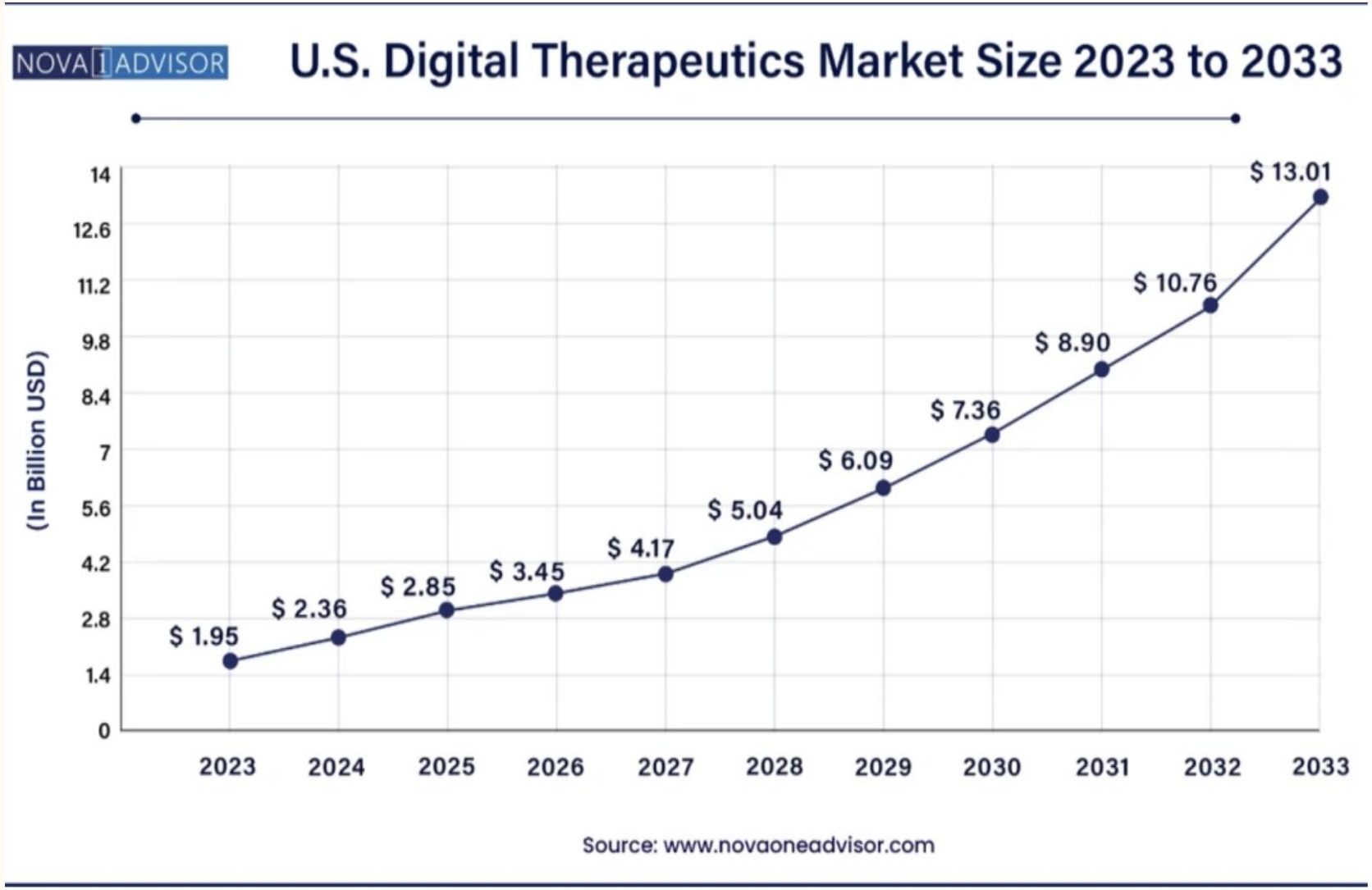
Appendix

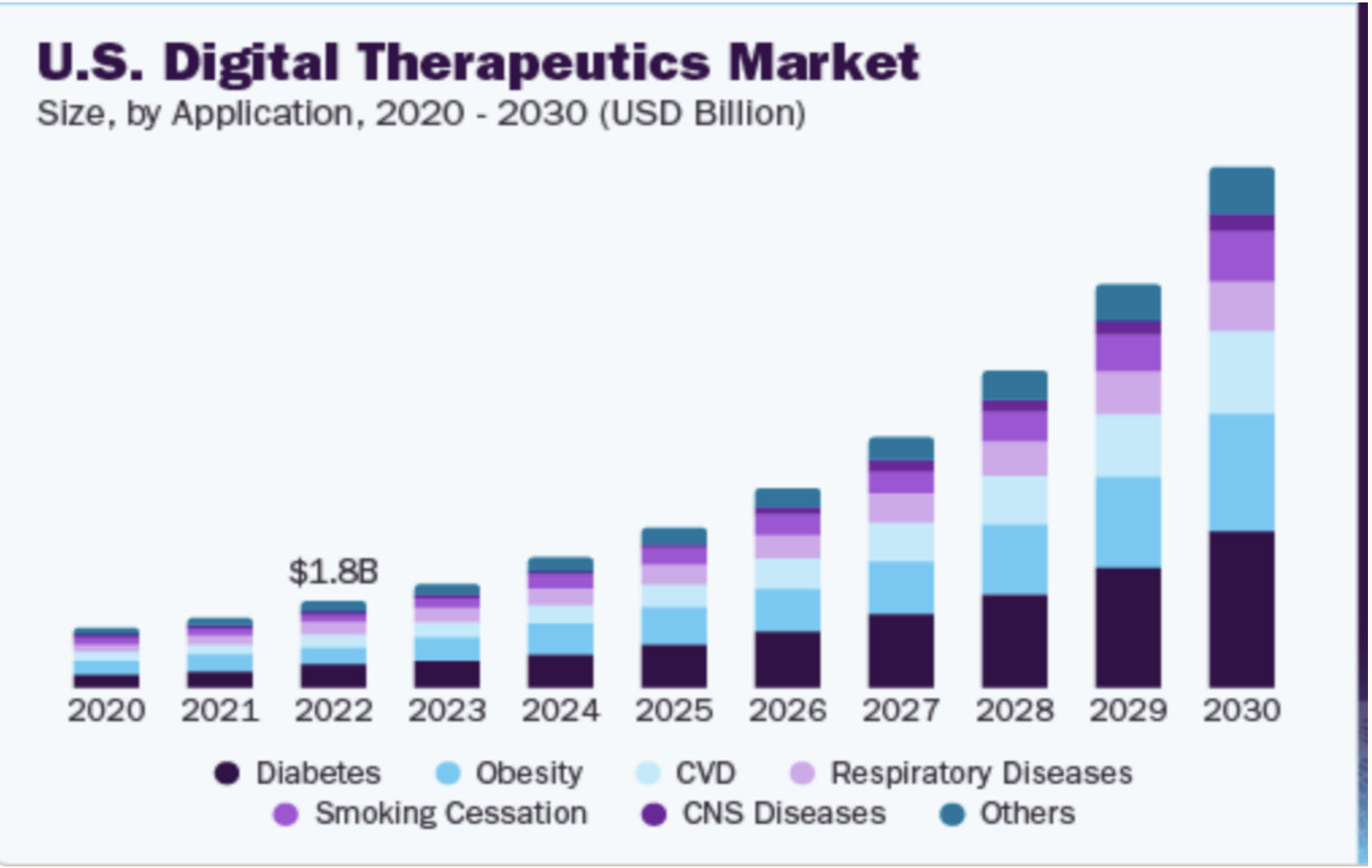
The Digital Therapy Market is Experiencing Explosive Growth, Expected to Surpass $13 Billion by 2033



Key Observations:

- The U.S. digital therapeutics market, valued at USD 1.95 billion in 2023, is projected to grow at a CAGR of 20.9%, reaching approximately USD 13.01 billion by 2033 during the forecast period from 2024 to 2033.
- From $1.95 billion in 2023 to $13.01 billion in 2033, the growth represents a 6.67x increase.

More Consumers Are Expected to Adopt Digital Therapeutics for Chronic Disease and Mental Health Management



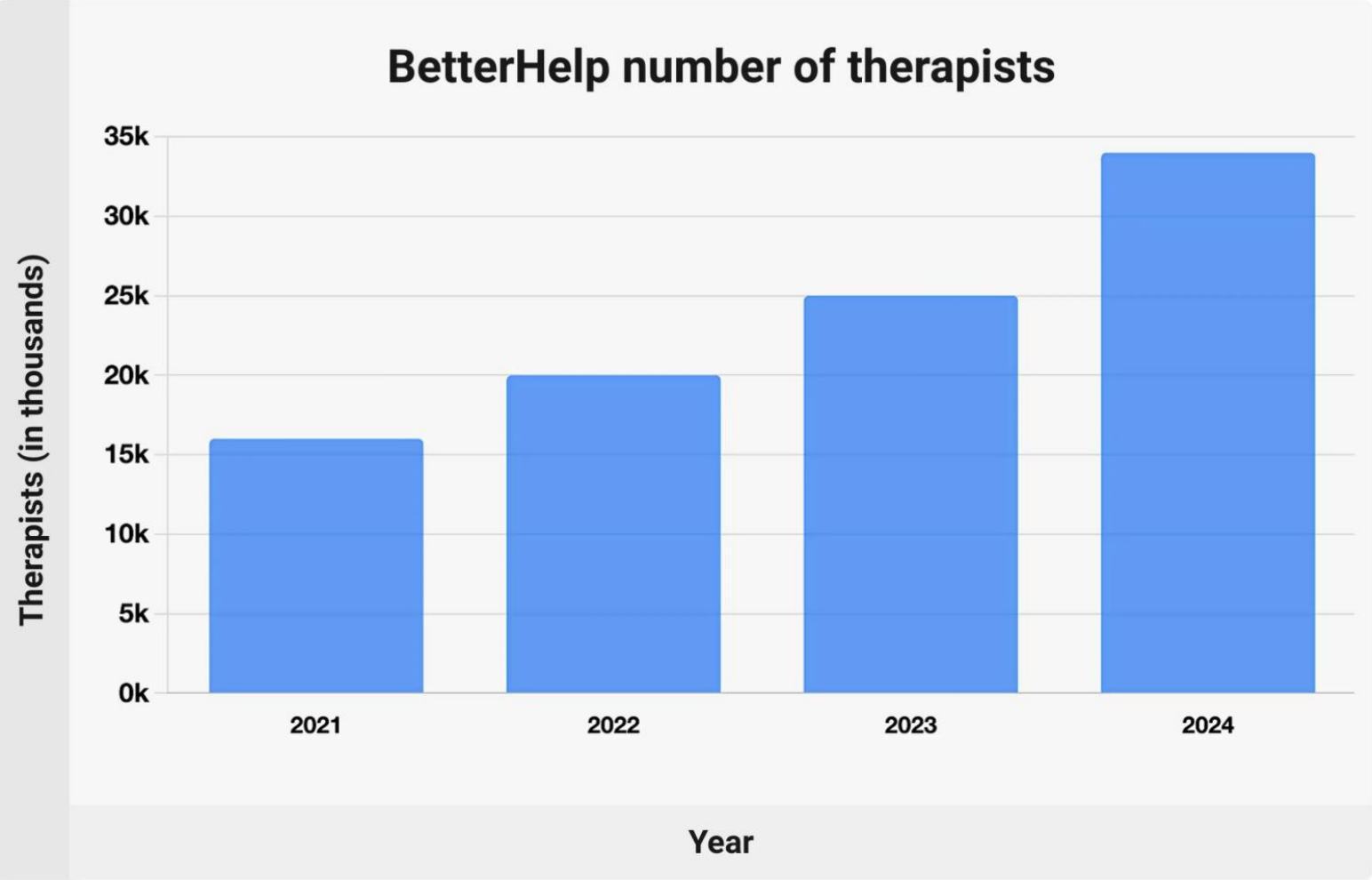
Key Observations:

- The largest user base in digital therapeutics will remain diabetes patients.
- CNS disorders (mental health conditions like anxiety, depression, and neurological diseases) are the second-largest segment, and this sector is expected to see rapid growth, likely due to AI-driven therapy tools and telehealth adoption.
- The expansion of the "Others" category in later years suggests that more users outside of traditional chronic disease management are adopting digital therapeutics.

BetterHelp
Consumer Analysis

- Customer Segments
  - Therapist.
  - Patients.

BetterHelp's Therapist Network Has More Than Doubled Since 2021, Surpassing 34,000 in 2024



Key Observations:

- The number of therapists has grown an average of 30% over the past 4 years.
- The upward trend suggests an increasing demand for online mental health services and BetterHelp's capacity to scale its workforce accordingly.

BetterHelp Serves a Diverse Range of Age Groups, Catering to Users Across All Generations

Age Range	Percentage
18 - 24	17.55%
25 - 34	33.49%
35 - 44	20.33%
45 - 54	14.6%
55 - 64	9.02%
65+	5.02%

BetterHelp's User By Age

Key Observations:

- Millennials Are the Primary Users of BetterHelp, With 25-34 Year Olds Leading at 33.49%
- Usage Declines with Age but Remains Present in Older Demographics.
- 53.82% of users fall within the 25-44 age bracket, reinforcing that working professionals and younger adults are the primary users of BetterHelp.

BetterHelp's User Base is Dominated by the U.S., Accounting for Over Two-Thirds of Traffic

Country		All devices	Desktop	Mobile
United States	66.49%	4.15M	52.05%	47.95%
United Kingdom	8.1%	506.12K	51.17%	48.83%
India	2.2%	137.59K	22.68%	77.32%
Canada	1.92%	119.83K	61.24%	38.76%
Australia	1.69%	105.38K	61.02%	38.98%

BetterHelp Website Traffic (2025)

Key Observation:

- BetterHelp's primary market is in the United States, as 66.49% of BetterHelp's traffic comes from the U.S., with over 4.15 million visitors.

What Users Crave: Insights from Real Mental Health App Users

According to Pew's 2023 survey, only about 1 in 5 people (20%) would want to use an AI mental health chatbot if they were seeking help, whereas the vast majority (79%) would prefer a human therapist or are uncomfortable with AI alone. This sentiment chart (see the blue bars) underscores that most users are not ready to replace human empathy with algorithms. Instead, many favor a blended approach – using digital tools alongside human care. This indicates a strong preference for hybrid models or traditional therapy over AI-only care among the public.

One 2024 study found 81% of people would rather talk to a human about their mental health, versus only 4% who would choose a chatbot.
These insights underscore that real users crave human connection in mental health care – AI tools may help, but not without human-led guidance.

Sources: Pew Research Center; JMIR Human Factors Journal

Large majority of Americans do not want to use an AI chatbot to support their mental health

% of U.S. adults who say they would ___ to use an artificial intelligence chatbot if they were seeking mental health support

Note: Respondents who did not give an answer are not shown.
Source: Survey conducted Dec. 12-18, 2022.
"60% of Americans Would Be Uncomfortable With Provider Relying on AI in Their Own Health Care"

PEW RESEARCH CENTER

Table 3. People's preferences of a bot and a real person in various health scenarios.

Would you prefer a bot or a real person when...	Bot, n (%)	Person, n (%)	Don't mind, n (%)	Did not respond, n (%)[a]
Speaking about general health (n=600)	18 (3.0)	484 (80.7)	98 (16.3)	288 (32.4)
Speaking about mental health (n=596)	26 (4.4)	483 (81.0)	87 (14.6)	292 (32.9)
Speaking about sleep (n=595)	46 (7.7)	370 (62.2)	179 (30.1)	293 (33.0)
Speaking about nutrition (n=599)	64 (10.7)	343 (57.3)	192 (32.1)	289 (32.5)
Collecting symptoms (n=590)	63 (10.7)	270 (45.8)	257 (43.6)	298 (33.6)
Conducting preliminary analysis (n=596)	72 (12.1)	314 (52.7)	210 (35.2)	292 (32.9)

[a]Percentages in this column are based on the total 888 respondents.

Pain Points

Making AI Therapy More Human-Centered

Problem	Solutions	Business Impact
• Lack of emotional connection with AI driven therapy. • User experiences have highlighted that some responses felt templated or AI-generated, weakening the sense of human connection during therapy.	• AI-powered real-time sentiment analysis will augment but not replace human empathy by analyzing speech, tone, text, and facial expressions during sessions. • Running in the background, it will highlight emotional shifts and provides subtle cues to help therapists catch signals they might miss during therapy enhancing response accuracy and session quality.	• Better: Enhances therapy quality by surfacing emotional cues therapists may miss, ensuring AI supports and not replaces human empathy. • Faster: Detects emotional distress in real time, enabling therapists to respond more quickly during sessions.

Therapists will be in Control of Treatment Decisions

Problem	Solutions	Business Impact
• Concerns Over AI-Driven Decision-Making in Therapy. • Customers have expressed growing concerns about AI tools having too much influence over final clinical decision	• Prioritize AI as a tool to augment and not replace therapists in the decision-making process. • Implement a therapist override system where therapists can review, edit, or reject any AI-generated suggestions (e.g: treatment goals, follow-ups, risk flags), ensuring the final decision always rests with the human expert.	• **Safer**: Preserves clinical authority with therapists, preventing overreliance on AI and safeguarding against inappropriate recommendations. • **Better**: Enhances care quality by reassuring clients that therapy is driven by professional expertise, not AI decisions. • **Other**: Strengthens customer loyalty and therapist engagement, increasing retention and boosting lifetime customer value for sustained revenue growth

Smarter AI Will Lighten Therapist Workload

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Problem	Solutions	Business Impact
• Increased administrative tasks for therapists due to the need to review and correct AI-generated session reports, which often lack accuracy. This added workload may reduce time available for patient care.	• Improve the training of NLP models so they can better understand the language and context used in therapy sessions. • Use therapist feedback to continuously refine the AI, making reports more accurate and reducing common errors. While therapists will continue reviewing reports, continuously refining AI accuracy using their feedback will significantly reduce the time and effort needed for corrections.	• **Faster**: Reduces administrative workload for therapists by minimizing the need for edits and corrections. • **Better:** Builds therapist trust by incorporating their input into AI improvements. • **Cheaper:** Lowers operational costs by reducing reliance on admin support and mitigating therapist burnout, helping avoid over hiring.

Clear Ethical Boundaries Will Make AI in Therapy Safer and More Trusted

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Problem

- Privacy, Ethical, and Compliance Risks in AI-Driven Mental Health
- In 2023, BetterHelp was fined $7.8 million by the FTC for sharing sensitive mental health data with advertisers, raising significant privacy and ethical concerns.

Solutions

- Establish a strong Ethical AI Framework ensuring full HIPAA and FTC compliance.
- Adopt end-to-end encryption to secure sensitive mental health data.
- Implement a therapist-facing dashboard showing how AI-generated recommendations are made, increasing transparency and trust.

Business Impact

- **Safer:** Minimizes legal risks and protects against fines through strong HIPAA and FTC compliance.
- **Better**: Builds long-term trust with customers and improves therapist confidence by reducing ethical uncertainty.
- **Other:** Enhances customer retention by increasing accountability, transparency, and overall platform trustworthiness.

Personas

User Personas

Persona Name	Demographic Focus	Behavioral Traits	Pain Points	AI Value Proposition
Emily – Millennial with Type 2 Diabetes	31, Female, Single, Product Manager, Chicago, IL	Digitally savvy, Overworks, Health-conscious but anxious	Struggles with work-health balance, AI lacks empathy, Therapy rigidity	Sentiment-aware summaries, async therapy, tracks emotional-physical links
Andre – Educator with Obesity & Depression	28, Male, Unmarried, High School Teacher, Detroit, MI	Low motivation, Avoids in-person therapy, Privacy-aware	Feels judged, Low therapy consistency, AI mistrust	Bias-checked summaries, gamified assessments, flexible scheduling
Samira – Millennial Mom with PCOS & Anxiety	33, Female, Married, Part-time Healthcare Admin, Dallas, TX	Busy mom, Emotionally reactive, Seeks flexible options	Mood swings, Limited time, Uncertainty with AI trust	Mood tracking, personalized nudges, therapist-informed AI reports

Behavioral Trends by Persona Type

Persona Type	Engagement Style	AI Feature Use	Drop-off Risk	Retention Factors
Busy Professionals	Flexible, async use	Session summaries	Medium	Personalized AI + emotional tone match
Young Adults	Inconsistent sessions	Mood trackers	High	Early trust-building, relatable prompts
Caregivers/Parents	Night-time or sporadic	Journals + Reminders	Medium	Flexible timing, therapist-assisted AI

Factors Influencing Retention & Satisfaction

- **Emotional resonance** in AI content (tone & empathy)
- **Transparency** in how AI processes and generates outputs
- **Customization** of AI feedback styles based on persona preferences
- **Therapist involvement** in reviewing AI-driven insights

Optimizing the Customer Journey: Recommendations for Improvement

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Patient

Increase Transparency Before Signup

A) Provide **therapist previews & specialties** before payment.

B) Clarify **pricing, insurance options, and refund policies** upfront.

Improve Therapist Matching & First Session Experience

A) Offer a **free initial consultation** or matching trial.

B) Enable **better AI-personalization** for therapy needs.

Enhance Engagement & Therapy Progress Tracking

A) Develop **custom therapy roadmaps** with milestones.

B) Provide **personalized check-ins** beyond AI-generated texts.

Simplify Subscription & Exit Process

A) Make **cancellation more user-friendly** to build trust.

B) Offer **pause options** instead of strict cancellations.

Therapist

Streamline Onboarding & Case Assignment

A) Reduce **verification wait times** for quicker enrollment.

B) Provide **more patient details upfront** before assignment.

Enhance Therapist-AI Collaboration

A) AI should **assist, not replace therapist decisions**.

B) Develop **AI-generated insights** that support but don't dictate therapy.

Improve Payment & Workload Flexibility

A) Offer **tiered payment structures** based on session demand.

B) Provide **better work-life balance tools** (automated scheduling).

Reduce Therapist Turnover with Better Incentives

A) Introduce **performance-based rewards** for retention.

B) Offer **professional development** and career growth opportunities.

Our Recommendations

Turning Raw Interaction Data into Actionable Clinical Intelligence

01 — Therapy session begins — video, audio, and chat streams are captured in real-time.

Live Session Initiation

02
- Speech-to-text conversion
- Frame-by-frame facial analysis
- Messages are time-stamped

Real-Time Data Capture

03
- Detects hesitations, tone changes.
- Maps expressions to emotion states.
- Scans text for risk indicators

Parallel AI Pipelines

04 — Compiles emotion trends, alerts, and follow-up prompts for review.

Session Summary

05 — Live in-session alerts + post-session summaries available on BetterHelp therapist portal.

Therapist Dashboard

Storage and Infra

- Cloud Storage: HIPAA-compliant AWS S3
- Processing: Real-time inference via AWS Lambda and SageMaker
- Retention: Anonymized data stored 30 days (with user consent)

Build vs. Buy – Strategic Considerations for Emotion AI Deployment

Criteria	Build In-House	Partner with Third Party (e.g., HireVue, Affectiva)
Customization	Fully tailored to BetterHelp's therapy model and compliance needs.	Limited to vendor capabilities; requires adaptation to existing APIs.
Cost Over Time	High upfront investment; lower operational costs long-term.	Minimal setup cost; recurring license/subscription fees over time.
Time to Deploy	6–12 months for MVP development and team training.	Available for integration within 2–4 weeks.
Data Ownership	Full control over storage, processing, and compliance.	Potential risks if data boundaries and ownership aren't clearly enforced.
Expertise Required	ML engineers, cloud devs, psychologists, legal/privacy teams.	Vendor handles technical stack and documentation.

Adopt a **hybrid approach**:
- Build core components in-house (e.g., NLP engine, risk flagging logic).
- Integrate emotion analytics via APIs from vendors like **Affectiva** or **HireVue**.
- Ensure clear **SLAs** (service-level agreements) and **data usage clauses** to meet HIPAA and FTC requirements.

Phased AI Rollout Strategy: From Pilot to Scalable Deployment

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Phase 01 Pilot Deployment

- Integrate third-party APIs (Affectiva/HireVue) into the AWS Lambda framework to enable real-time emotion detection with minimal lead time.
- Deploy the solution to a limited group of 5–10 therapists in controlled sessions.
- Capture therapist feedback to assess the relevance, accuracy, and usability of live emotion cues and AI-generated prompts.

Phase 02 Internal AI Development

- Train a custom NLP model using anonymized transcripts to enhance the precision of risk phrase detection and emotional trend mapping.
- Extend AI logic to include sentiment trajectory over session duration and contextual alert thresholds
- Key resource requirements: 2 Machine Learning Engineers, 1 Privacy Compliance Officer, and 1 UX Designer.

Phase 03 Full Scale Development

- Roll out opt-in encrypted session recording for users, with data securely stored to support ongoing model refinement.
- Establish weekly compliance routines for automated audit logging, version tracking, and performance benchmarking.
- Launch therapist onboarding workshops and feedback loops to normalize AI adoption and foster trust in the platform.

Infrastructure and Compliance Highlights

- AI models hosted on AWS with RBAC (Role-Based Access Controls) and HIPAA-grade encryption.
- Real-time inference powered by GPU-enabled SageMaker instances.
- 30-day retention policy for session data, maintained only with user consent.

This step-by-step plan helps BetterHelp test AI safely, improve it based on real feedback, and scale it across the platform while staying compliant and supporting therapists effectively.

Building and Maintaining BetterHelp's Emotion Recognition System

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Phase 01 (API based)

Setup Requirements

A) Cloud API calls for emotion analysis (per frame/audio sample)

B) Lightweight integration into video streaming flow

C) Monitoring tools for API usage, latency, and error handling

Maintenance Plan

A) Track API performance, costs, and reliability

B) Monitor user/therapist feedback on emotion metrics

Phase 02 & Phase 03(Internal AI)

Setup Requirements

A) GPU-enabled servers or cloud AI platforms (AWS G4, SageMaker)

B) Real-time video/audio processing pipeline with autoscaling

C) Model training setup using labeled therapy session clips (with consent)

D) CI/CD pipelines for model deployment and updates

Maintenance Plan

A) Setup model retraining schedule and feedback loops

B) Implement drift detection, error recovery, and QA validation

C) Maintain real-time model performance metrics & fallback systems

D) Ensure continuous security & compliance checks (HIPAA, GDPR)

E) Ensure that timely workshops take place to onboard new therapists and familiarize them to the adoption of AI

Evaluating Costs across the AI Rollout Lifecycle at BetterHelp

Phase 01

a) ~$2 to $3 per session for facial/ tone/ sentiment analysis via APIs

b) Cost effective for pilot & early scale adoption

Phase 02

a) One time development cost - $500K to $1M for model building, training and infrastructure

b) Ongoing compute + talent costs (~$50K to $150K/m depending on scale)

Phase 03

a) Scales effectively with usage – lower marginal costs over time

b) Cost of setting up workshops for therapists to help them understand and normalize AI through feedback loops.

Optional Licensing/M&A

a) Licensing emotion SDKs: $200K to $500K/year

b) Acquiring niche startups (e.g., **Kintsugi**): $10M to $20M+

Competitor Analysis

Evaluating the AI Rollout Lifecycles

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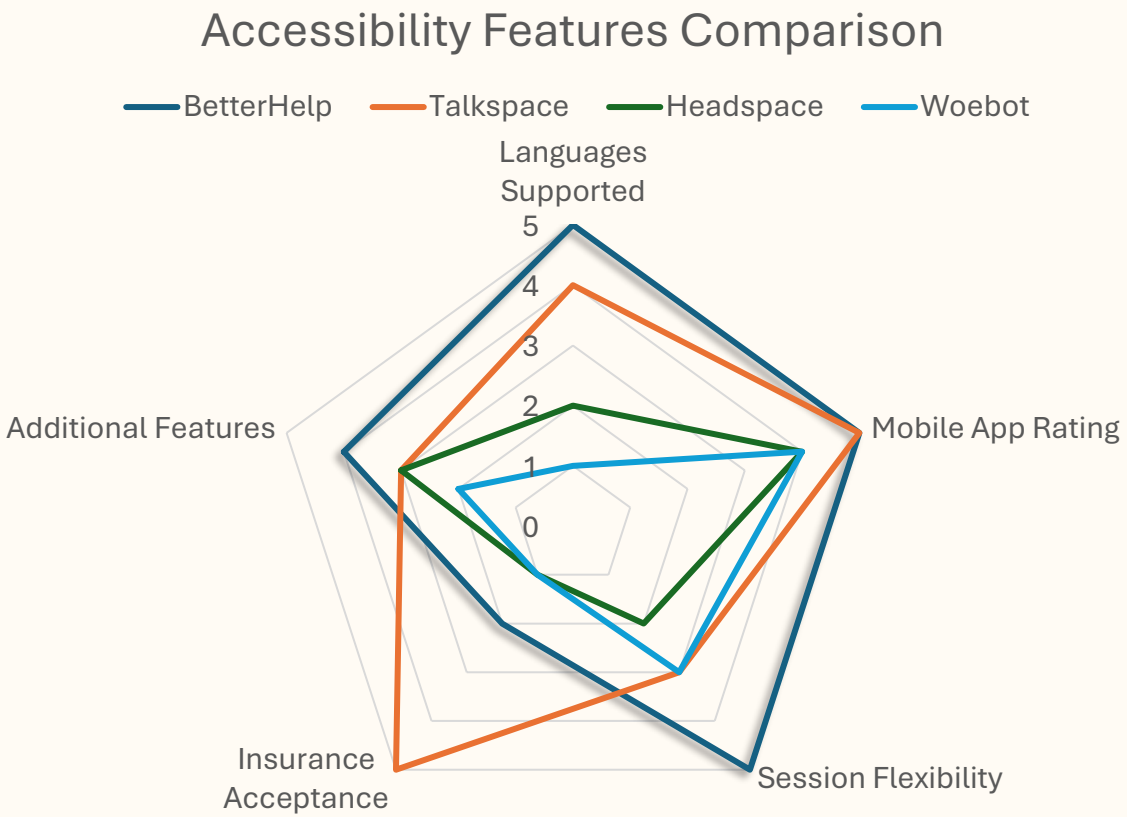
Competitors	Current technology	Key Outcomes of current Tech
TalkSpace	• **AI Notes & Podcasts:** Smart Notes and Talkcast use GPT to generate therapy content & documentation • **Crisis Detection:** NLP system flags suicide risks with 83% accuracy • **Matching Algorithm:** Filters therapists by preferences, specialty, and experience	90% of users found Talkcast helpful; rapid therapist assignment
Headspace	• No AI used in therapy content • **Matching:** Rule-based filtering by insurance, availability, language, etc. • **AI Assistant:** Partnered with Kiwi Health for AI-powered patient scheduling and booking support	• Over 1 million sessions/year; • 26,000+ providers; • fast access to in-network therapists
Cerebral	• **AI Documentation:** GPT-based tools draft clinical notes and patient-facing messages • **Crisis Risk Detection:** NLP-based triage reduces response time from hours to ~10 minutes • **ML Matching:** Matches clients and providers based on specialty, cultural fit, and preferences	81% improvement in documentation compliance; 78% reduction in audit time
Amwell	• **Digital CBT:** SilverCloud provides personalized therapy journeys using AI • **Voice-Based Documentation:** Suki AI assists with real-time therapy note generation • **Chatbot Intake:** Conversa handles triage, symptom tracking, and follow-up	95% visit success rate; 65–70% improvement in CBT program user

BetterHelp Leads the Pack: Balancing Pricing, Accessibility, and Features

BetterHelp hits a **sweet spot** of **affordability and accessibility**: it charges a flat moderate fee that, for many, is “a pretty good deal” compared to traditional therapy, and it removes barriers like session caps or complex plans. Its platform is widely accessible (multi-device, many languages, global reach) without needing insurance, which opens the door to anyone seeking help. When stacked against competitors, BetterHelp balances cost, flexibility, and features **most favorably** – offering unlimited communication, included weekly live sessions, and a rich toolkit of resources, all for one transparent price.



BetterHelp's Hybrid Edge:
A Strategic SWOT Snapshot for AI-Enhanced Care

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Strengths	Weakness
• Combines **real human therapists** with AI tools for personalization • Uses **evidence-based therapy** (CBT, DBT) — trusted and clinically proven • Aligns with user preference for **hybrid care** (79% prefer human support – Pew, 2023) • **AI matches users** to best-fit therapists, enhancing engagement	• No **AI chatbot** for real-time interaction (unlike Woebot or Headspace) • **Scalability limited** by need for licensed professionals • May appear less “tech-advanced” to users expecting constant chatbot availability
Opportunities	**Threats**
• Introduce AI-powered **smart journaling insights** and **session summaries** • Expand globally with **localized therapist matching** + culturally adaptive AI • Position as the **“best of both worlds”** – human **empathy** + intelligent tech	• AI-first platforms (Woebot, Headspace) offer **instant 24/7 interaction**, drawing tech-seeking users • Rising trend of **AI chatbot acceptance** could pressure BetterHelp to automate more aggressively • Rising trend of **AI chatbot acceptance** could pressure BetterHelp to automate more aggressively

Support Tools and Strategic Takeaways

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Talkspace

- Mobile/web therapy platform with integrated symptom tracking and insurance billing
- Focused on developing AI tools to support therapists, not replace them
- **Strategic Direction**: Empower clinicians with AI-generated insights and documentation tools

Headspace

- AI audit tools ensure documentation quality and reduce insurance denial risk
- Telehealth platform includes symptom tracking, psychiatry, and e-prescription features
- **Strategic Direction:** Enhance care quality, safety, and personalization through AI

Cerebral

- End-to-end scheduling, intake, and insurance verification for independent therapists
- Provides documentation templates and claim automation
- **Strategic Direction:** Expand affordable therapy access through tech-enabled private practice support

Amwell

- Enterprise-grade platform with EHR integration, secure cloud, and scalable APIs
- Offers full hybrid care: live therapy, AI triage, and self-guided digital therapy
- **Strategic Direction:** Build a scalable, integrated behavioral health ecosystem for health systems and payers

Ensuring continuous therapy sessions with zero downtime

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Risk Involved

- Potential for AI system downtime during critical therapy interactions
- High-availability essential for real-time therapy needs (24/7 availability)

Why it's crucial

- Downtime risks client safety and significantly damages platform credibility
- Clients rely on uninterrupted, timely mental health support

Mitigation

- **Scalable cloud infrastructure**: Geographic redundancy to avoid outages
- **Automated proactive monitoring**: Rapid detection and resolution of system issues
- **Regular stress-testing**: Ensures readiness for peak usage demands and prevents bottlenecks

Protecting user data must be central to AI integration

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Risk Involved

- AI tools in BetterHelp rely on highly sensitive personal data including therapy transcripts, emotional states, health histories, and behavioral patterns
- Without strong encryption and access control, this data is vulnerable to breaches, misuse, or unauthorized third-party sharing
- BetterHelp was fined $7.8M by the FTC for unauthorized data sharing and misleading HIPAA claims

Why it's crucial

- Trust in data privacy directly impacts client retention and platform credibility
- End-to-end encryption (E2EE) is critical to ensure that sensitive data remains unreadable during storage, transmission, and processing — even from internal employees or platform providers
- Modern AI systems may unintentionally store logs, summaries, or unencrypted metadata, which can be leaked or misused if not properly secured

Mitigation

- **End-to-End Encryption (E2EE)**: Encrypt all client data (text, video, audio); restrict access internally
- **Data Minimization & Segmentation**: Limit AI to essential fields using data masking, separate personal information from session content
- **Anonymized Model Training**: Apply federated learning and differential privacy to protect training data
- **Compliance Monitoring & Consent**: Conduct Privacy Impact Assessments (PIAs), ensure clear, opt-in user consent

Managing AI bias through diverse and inclusive data

Risk Involved

- AI tools in therapy may unintentionally reflect biases (racial, gender, cultural, socio-economic) if trained on non-representative datasets
- Inaccurate or generalized recommendations can lead to unequal experiences and outcomes for different user groups

Why it's crucial

- Ensuring fairness in AI decisions is vital to maintain BetterHelp's credibility, especially when serving diverse, global users
- Biased AI outputs could negatively impact vulnerable individuals, compounding mental health challenges

Mitigation

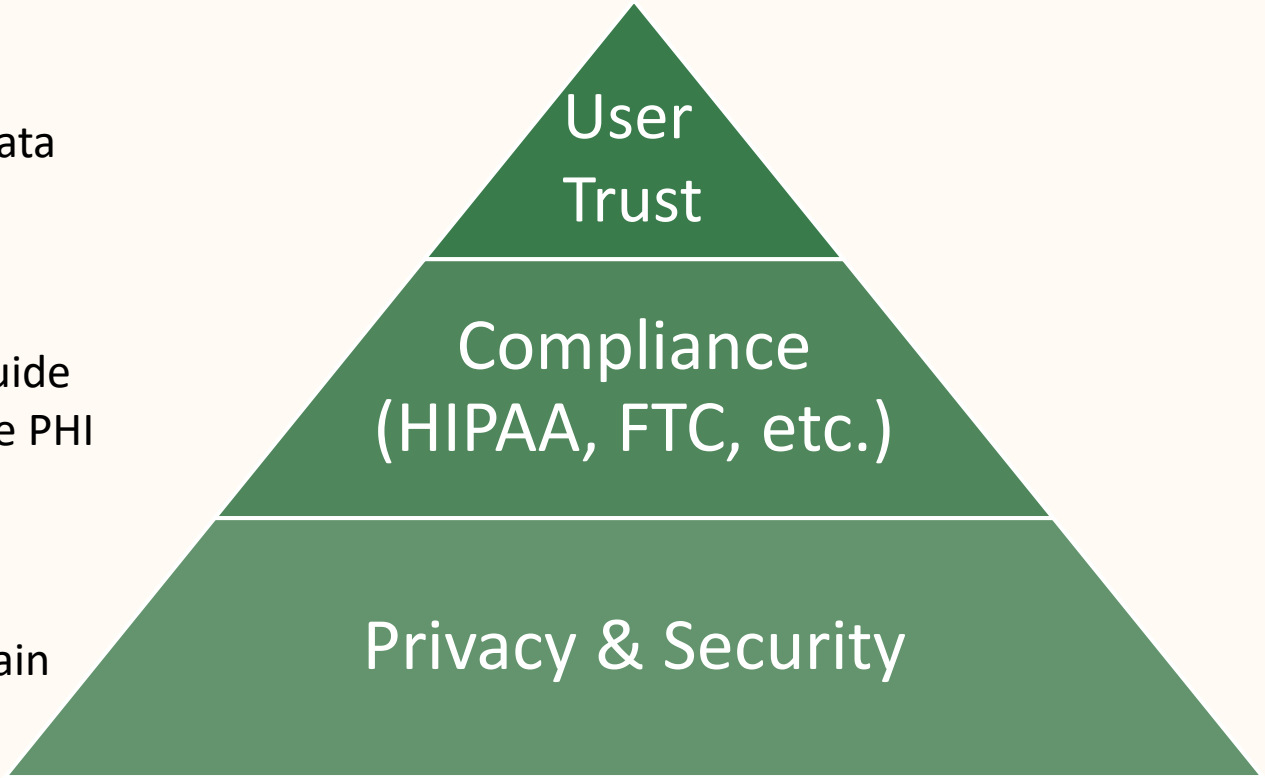
- **Diverse & Inclusive Training Data**: Prioritize datasets representing different ethnicities, gender identities, age groups, and cultural backgrounds
- **Bias Detection and Testing**: Regularly audit AI outputs across demographic segments to identify and correct unfair patterns
- **Ethical AI Development Guidelines**: Establish internal protocols for evaluating dataset diversity, fairness metrics, and responsible AI deployment

Securing Trust Through Compliance

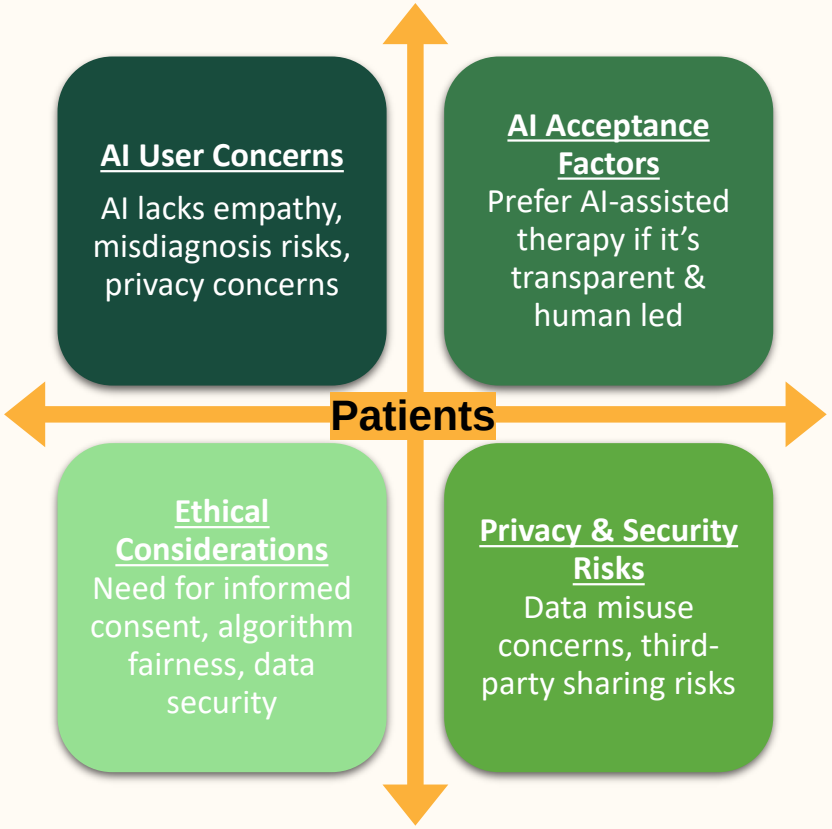
- **Trust = Security + Privacy**
  Patients and therapists need reassurance that sensitive data will not be exposed or misused.

- **Legal Mandates**
  HIPAA's Privacy, Security, and Breach Notification Rules guide how telehealth solutions must store, transmit, and handle PHI (Protected Health Information).

- **Alignment with Industry Norms**
  Telehealth providers who excel in security attract and retain users in a competitive market.

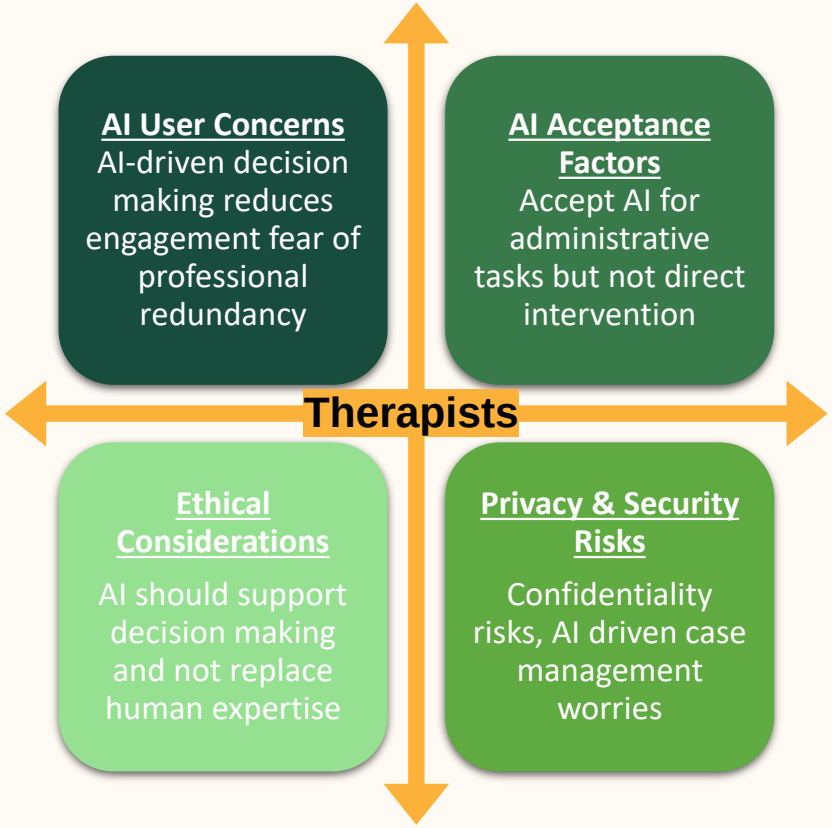


Building Trust in AI-Driven Therapy: Perspectives of Patient & Therapist



Recommendations to improve trust in AI

a) Transparency:
Clear AI disclaimers & data policies.
b) User Control:
Opt-in AI assistance, personalized AI settings.
c) AI-Human Balance:
AI assists should be present, but therapists lead sessions.



Fortify Your Telehealth Stack: Encryption, Cloud Infrastructure & More

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Network Hardening

Protect not just the app interface (patient or therapist interface), but everything behind it, like the network, data storage, and servers using a layered security approach.

Encryption

Make sure all data is encrypted, while being sent (TLS 1.3) and when stored (AES-256) so that sensitive health info (PHI) stays safe from prying eyes.

Key Management & BAA

Choose HIPAA-compliant cloud providers like AWS, Azure, or Google Cloud. They offer the tools and agreements (BAAs) we need to handle patient data securely.

Control & Monitor:
Effective RBAC + Real-Time Audits

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Role-Based Access Control (RBAC) enforces the “minimum necessary” principle, preventing unauthorized staff or systems from viewing sensitive information.

Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA) protects against credential theft. Therapists, patients, and admins each have distinct permission layers.

Continuously track user and system activity through a **Security Incident and Event Management (SIEM)** system, it is a centralized solution that **collects, analyzes, and alerts on logs** from servers, apps, and devices so that any suspicious behavior can be **spotted early** and addressed immediately.

NLP-Based Scrubbing Natural Language Processing (NLP) can detect and remove identifying details (names, locations) before cloud storage.

- Rigorous access controls and real-time monitoring deter breaches and fulfill critical HIPAA requirements.
- By scrubbing sensitive details and minimizing data collection, we can protect patient identity while enabling AI-driven insights.

How competitors are building Trust Through Responsible AI and Data Ethics

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Concern	Woebot	Talkspace	Headspace
Data Privacy	• Treats all user data as Protected Health Information (PHI) • Adheres to HIPAA and GDPR requirements • Does not sell user data to advertisers	• Collects user data, including chat transcripts. • Privacy policies allow data collection before subscription	• Collects user data for service personalization • Shares data with third-party service providers
HIPAA Compliance	• Aligns with HIPAA Privacy and Security Rules • Implements industry best practices to protect sensitive user data	• Claims to be HIPAA compliant • Uses encryption to maintain client confidentiality	• Not a HIPAA-covered entity • Privacy practices may not adhere to HIPAA standards
Ethical AI Practices	• Faced scrutiny over the depth and empathy of AI responses • Emphasizes human oversight in AI-driven tools to maintain empathetic understanding	• Utilizes AI to analyze anonymized therapy transcripts • Aims to improve services through machine learning	• Employs AI to personalize meditation and mindfulness experiences • Focuses on user privacy and data security in AI applications